

Formal pronouns in Spanish and the case for [HON]

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Abstract

In Spanish, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all (formal only in Spain)’ behave semantically as second-person arguments but appear with third-person verb forms and pronominal clitics, a mismatch that raises the question of whether these pronouns are second person or third person at the level of syntax. By applying a variety of diagnostics, including novel ones that relate to the Person-Case Constraint and pronoun-noun constructions, I determine that *usted* and *ustedes* are syntactically second person and must therefore be distinguished as vocabulary items from the other second-person pronouns of Spanish. To this end, I propose that both expressions are generated with an [HON(ORIFIC)] feature, one that is involved in one or more postsyntactic impoverishment processes, in addition to a [PARTICIPANT] feature. In all varieties of Spanish, [HON] triggers the deletion of [PART] during morphological operations, thereby preventing *usted* and *ustedes* from establishing second-person agreement. Moreover, in Latin American Spanish, [HON] is eliminated in the context of [PL(URAL)] at logical form, the result of which is that *ustedes* does not convey formality in these varieties despite its transparent morphological connection to *usted*. Not only does this analysis capture the unique semantic and syntactic properties of *usted* and *ustedes* in Spanish, but it also lays the groundwork for an account of etymologically related pronouns in other Romance languages, such as *vostè* ‘you (formal)’ and *vostès* ‘you all (formal)’ in Catalan and *você* ‘you, you (formal)’ and *vocês* ‘you all’ in Portuguese.

Keywords: Pronouns, Honorificity, Person, Agreement, Impoverishment, Imposters

1 Introduction

There are two principal ways in which languages come to express formality through their pronominal systems, both of which are attested in the Romance family. One strategy is to grammaticalize a nominal expression, as in (1), and another is to repurpose an existing pronoun, as in (2).¹

- (1) Spanish
 - a. *vuestra merced* ‘your mercy’ → *usted* ‘you (formal)’
 - b. *vuestras mercedes* ‘your mercies’ → *ustedes* ‘you all (formal only in Spain)’
- (2) Italian
 - a. *lei* ‘she’ → *Lei* ‘you (formal)’
 - b. *loro* ‘they’ → *Loro* ‘you all (formal)’

In this article, I explore issues that are particular to the first path to formality: how to evaluate whether pronouns that have nominal origins are indeed pronouns and, if so, how to differentiate them as vocabulary items from the rest of a language’s pronominal inventory. This endeavor yields an analysis of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish that accounts for their contrasting semantic and syntactic behavior in (3) and (4), where these pronouns are second person in interpretation but occur with verbs and pronominal clitics that are third person in form.²

- (3) a. *Usted* {es / *eres} lingüista.
 you is are.2SG linguist
 ‘You (formal) are a linguist.’
 b. *Ustedes* {son / *sois} lingüistas.
 you.PL are.3PL are.2PL linguists
 ‘You all are linguists.’
- (4) a. {Lo / La / *Te} conozco a usted.
 3SG.ACC 3SG.F.ACC 2SG know.1SG DOM you
 ‘I know you (formal).’
 b. {Los / Las / *Os} conozco a ustedes.
 3PL.ACC 3PL.F.ACC 2PL know.1SG DOM you.PL
 ‘I know you all.’

Based solely on these types of data, it is impossible to determine the featural composition of *usted* and *ustedes* at the start of their grammatical lives. If these pronouns are syntactically second person, one must explain why they fail to trigger second-person agreement, and if they are syntactically third person, or underspecified for person, one must explain how they come to refer to the addressee of the discourse context.

¹Unless the focus is specifically on the varieties of Peninsular Spanish that have more than one plural form of address, I translate *ustedes* as ‘you all’ moving forward.

²Stressed, or strong, pronouns require differential object marking (DOM) in Spanish (Jaeggli 1982, Laca 1987, Brugè and Brugger 1996, Torrego Salcedo 1999, Bleam 2005, Laca 2006, Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2007, Leonetti 2008, Fábregas 2013).

As it turns out, both positions have recently been defended in the literature: Arregi and Nevins (2018) characterize *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ as the default second-person pronouns of Spanish, while Collins and Ordóñez (2021) take them to be third-person imposters.³ To settle the debate, I consider syntactic environments in Spanish that disallow either second-person or third-person pronouns and find that *usted* and *ustedes* pattern like second-person pronouns in all cases. After identifying these forms as syntactically second person, which I represent through a [PART(ICIPANT)] feature, I attribute the lack of second-person agreement to a postsyntactic rule of impoverishment that results in the deletion of this feature. I propose that the catalyst for this process is an [HON(ORIFIC)] feature that is exclusive to *usted* and *ustedes* and is independently motivated by the need to distinguish these vocabulary items from the other second-person pronouns of Spanish.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. In section 2, I review the evidence that Collins and Ordóñez (2021) adduce in favor of their claim that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are third-person imposters and demonstrate that it is inconclusive at best. In section 3, I establish that *usted* and *ustedes* cannot be third-person pronouns or imposters because they are sensitive to the Person-Case Constraint in Spanish, just as second-person pronouns are. In section 4, I bolster this finding by showing that *usted* and *ustedes* behave like second-person pronouns rather than third-person pronouns or imposters in terms of their ability to appear in pronoun-noun constructions, such as *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’. In section 5, I introduce the theoretical framework of Distributed Morphology and the approach to person features that I employ in my analysis of *usted* and *ustedes*. In section 6, I argue that these pronouns are generated with an [HON] feature in addition to a [PART] feature and that [HON] participates in two types of impoverishment processes. First, in all varieties of Spanish, [HON] triggers the elimination of [PART] in the morphological component of the grammar, which renders *usted* and *ustedes* incapable of second-person agreement. Second, in Latin American Spanish, [HON] is deleted in the environment of [PL(URAL)] at logical form and thus does not factor into the interpretation of *ustedes*. In section 7, I propose a denotation for [HON] such that this feature makes the same semantic contribution, when it survives logical form, in *usted* and *ustedes*. Finally, in section 8, I conclude and discuss the crosslinguistic implications of this research.

2 Pronouns versus imposters

As defined by Collins and Postal (2012: 6) in (5), an imposter is a referential expression that displays incongruous semantic and syntactic properties.

- (5) An imposter is a notionally X person DP that is grammatically Y person, $X \neq Y$.

In the context of a restaurant, for instance, a server could use a definite description like *la señora* ‘the lady’ or *las señoras* ‘the ladies’ to address an individual or a group of individuals, as in (6).

³Arregi and Nevins were the first to raise the possibility that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters, but they ultimately reject this view.

- (6) a. ¿La señora desearía ver la carta de vinos?
 the lady desire.COND see the menu of wines
 ‘Would Madam like to see the wine list?’
 b. ¿Las señoras desearían ver la carta de vinos?
 the ladies desire.COND.3PL see the menu of wines
 ‘Would Madams like to see the wine list?’

There is no question that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are notionally second person, but the fact that they occur with third-person agreement morphology does not entail that they are grammatically third person. Instead, their syntactic identity must be determined empirically, which is the objective of the first part of this article. In this section, I begin with the structures that Collins and Ordóñez (2021) assign to *usted* and *ustedes* and then consider the data that they offer in defense of their account.

To explain the mismatching semantic and syntactic behavior of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 250–251) posit that these expressions contain the two DP layers in (7), where the higher DP is phonologically null and the lower DP consists of an unpronounced second-person pronoun *tú* ‘you (informal)’ along with the head noun *usted*.

- (7) a. Structure of *usted*
 [_{DP} D [TÚ *usted*]]
 b. Structure of *ustedes*
 [_{DP} D [TÚ *usted*]-s]

For these authors, the second-person interpretation of *usted* and *ustedes* is due to the covert *tú* in the embedded DP, and the use of third-person agreement morphology stems from the purported nominality of *usted*.⁴ Given the degree of phonological reduction from *vuestra merced* ‘your mercy’ to *usted*, however, it is not necessarily the case that *-ed* in *usted* and *ustedes* corresponds to the lexical layer of the noun phrase. In section 4, I explicitly rule out this possibility on the basis of constructions like *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you linguists’ in Spanish, where N cannot be the position in which the pronoun is generated because it is occupied by *lingüistas* ‘linguists’. For now, I concentrate on the four phenomena that lead Collins and Ordóñez to classify *usted* and *ustedes* as imposters.

The first environment concerns postverbal subjects of commands. As indicated through the use of capitalization in (8), the second-person pronouns *tú* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ can only be overt after an imperative verb if the intended reading is contrastive (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 252).

- (8) a. ¡Coge {*tú / TÚ} el plato!
 pick.up.2SG you YOU the dish
 ‘YOU (informal) pick up the dish!’

⁴One could, alternatively, take the higher null D in (7) to be responsible for third-person agreement.

- b. ¡Coged { *vosotros / VOSOTROS } el plato!
 pick.up.2PL you.PL YOU.PL the dish
 ‘YOU ALL (informal) pick up the dish!’

This restriction does not extend to the pronouns *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in (9) or the imposters *la señora* ‘Madam’ and *las señoras* ‘Madams’ in (10), all of which can follow a command without being contrastive (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 252–253).

- (9) a. ¡Coja {usted / USTED} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV you YOU the dish
 ‘Pick up/YOU (formal) pick up the dish!’
 b. ¡Cojan {ustedes / USTEDES} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV.3PL you.PL YOU.PL the dish
 ‘Pick up/YOU ALL pick up the dish!’
 (10) a. ¡Coja {la señora / LA SEÑORA} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV the lady THE LADY the dish
 Approximate: ‘Madam/MADAM, pick up the dish!’
 b. ¡Cojan {las señoras / LAS SEÑORAS} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV.3PL the ladies THE LADIES the dish
 Approximate: ‘Madams/MADAMS, pick up the dish!’

At first glance, the examples in (8) through (10) appear to support the claim that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters, but there is a confounding factor that must be taken into account. As Fernández Soriano (1999: 1232) remarks, speakers may opt to include *usted* and *ustedes* to “make their attitude of courtesy, respect, or distance evident” (translation mine), especially in situations where they are giving a order to someone of higher social status. In light of this pragmatic explanation for the difference between (8) and (9), these facts alone do not confirm whether *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters.

Another context that involves postverbal subjects is no more informative regarding *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ than the previous one. As the data sets in (11) through (13) show, neither *tú* ‘you (informal)’ nor *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ can intervene between an auxiliary verb and a lexical verb unless they are used contrastively, whereas *usted*, *ustedes*, and the imposters *la señora* ‘Madam’ and *las señoras* ‘Madams’ can all do so (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 253–254).

- (11) a. Te irás { *tú / TÚ } acostumbrando al clima.
 2SG go.FUT.2SG you YOU getting.used to.the climate
 ‘YOU (informal) will get used to the climate.’
 b. Os iréis { *vosotros / VOSOTROS } acostumbrando al
 2PL go.FUT.2PL you.PL YOU.PL getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘YOU ALL (informal) will get used to the climate.’

- (12) a. Se irá {usted / USTED} acostumbrando al clima.
 3 go.FUT.3SG you YOU getting.used to.the climate
 ‘You/YOU (formal) will get used to the climate.’
- b. Se irán {ustedes / USTEDES} acostumbrando al clima.
 3 go.FUT.3PL you.PL YOU.PL getting.used to.the climate
 ‘You all/YOU ALL will get used to the climate.’
- (13) a. Se irá {la señora / LA SEÑORA} acostumbrando al
 3 go.FUT.3SG the lady THE LADY getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘Madam/MADAM will get used to the climate.’
- b. Se irán {las señoras / LAS SEÑORAS} acostumbrando al
 3 go.FUT.3PL the ladies THE LADIES getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘Madams/MADAMS will get used to the climate.’

Here as well, the possibility of using *usted*, *ustedes*, or an imposter in this syntactic position could be attributed to the speaker’s desire to convey politeness. Furthermore, building on another observation by Fernández Soriano (1999), third-person verb forms like *irá* ‘(you/he/she) will go’ and *irán* ‘(you all/they) will go’ are ambiguous in that they can occur with a subject that is semantically second person or third person, and the addition of *usted*, *ustedes*, or an imposter after the finite verb serves to clarify that the utterance is about the speaker’s interlocutor or interlocutors and not a third party. For these two reasons, this environment does not provide unassailable evidence that *usted* and *ustedes* are different from the other pronouns of Spanish.

The next phenomenon to examine is clitic doubling, or the use of a clitic together with a nominal or pronominal expression in object position. In (14), both *tú* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ must be doubled by a clitic, as is the case with all pronouns in Spanish (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 254–255).

- (14) a. *(Te) prometo a ti que mañana vendré.
 2SG promise.1SG to you that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you (informal) that I will come tomorrow.’
- b. *(Os) prometo a vosotros que mañana vendré.
 2PL promise.1SG to you.PL that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you all (informal) that I will come tomorrow.’

According to Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 255), the clitic can be omitted with *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ when these expressions appear as indirect objects, as in (15), but these authors also mention in a footnote that an anonymous reviewer reports that the clitic is obligatory, as do all speakers whom I have consulted no matter their variety of Spanish.

- (15) a. (Le) prometo a usted que mañana vendré.
 3SG.DAT promise.1SG to you that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you (formal) that I will come tomorrow.’
 b. (Les) prometo a ustedes que mañana vendré.
 3PL.DAT promise.1SG to you.PL that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you all that I will come tomorrow.’

In the *Nueva gramática de la lengua española*, the Real Academia Española (2009: 1245) reports that *usted* and *ustedes* can be used without an accompanying clitic only in formal speech and writing, such as a wedding invitation, which could explain the discrepancy in judgments. Curiously, when these pronouns serve as direct objects, as in (16), speakers find clitic doubling to be necessary even in formal registers.⁵

- (16) a. *(La) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM you to dine with us
 ‘We invite you (formal) to dine with us.’
 b. *(Las) invitamos a ustedes a cenar con nosotros.
 3PL.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM you.PL to dine with us
 ‘We invite you all to dine with us.’

These examples suggest that *usted* and *ustedes* are not, in fact, imposters since imposters and other nonpronominal arguments cannot be doubled by a clitic in the majority of Spanish varieties, as indicated in (17).

- (17) a. (*La) invitamos a la señora a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM the lady to dine with us
 ‘We invite Madam to dine with us.’
 b. (*Las) invitamos a las señoras a cenar con nosotros.
 3PL.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM the ladies to dine with us
 ‘We invite Madams to dine with us.’

Even in those varieties that do permit clitic doubling with animate direct objects, such as Rioplatense Spanish, there is still a contrast between the requirement of the clitic in (18a) and the optionality of the clitic in (18b).⁶

- (18) Rioplatense Spanish
 a. *(La) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM you to dine with us
 ‘We invite you (formal) to dine with us.’

⁵This observation extends to *leísta* varieties, or those that use the dative clitics *le* and *les* in place of the accusative clitics *lo* and *los* when the referent is animate: **(le) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros* ‘we invite you (formal) to dine with us’ and **(les) invitamos a ustedes a cenar con nosotros* ‘we invite you all to dine with us’.

⁶There is a large body of descriptive and theoretical work that discusses clitic doubling in Rioplatense Spanish (Jaeggli 1982, 1986; Suñer 1988, 1989; Fernández Soriano 1993, 1999; Di Tullio and Zdrojewski 2006; Di Tullio et al. 2019; Fischer et al. 2019).

- b. (La) invitamos a la señora a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM the lady to dine with us
 ‘We invite Madam to dine with us.’

In short, this closer investigation of clitic doubling in Spanish undermines rather than corroborates the view that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters.

The last construction to explore is the use of a postnominal stressed pronoun together with a prenominal possessive determiner. Focusing on certain varieties of Peninsular Spanish, Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 256–257) note that the second-person pronouns in (19), the third-person pronouns in (20), and the nominal expressions in (21) are all disallowed in this context, unlike *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in (22) and the imposters in (23).

- (19) a. tu libro (*de ti)
 your book of you
 ‘your (informal) book’
 b. vuestros libros (*de vosotros)
 your.PL books of you.PL
 ‘your (informal) books’
- (20) a. su libro (*de él)
 his book of him
 ‘his book’
 b. sus libros (*de ellos)
 their books of them
 ‘their books’
- (21) a. su libro (*de Juan)
 his book of Juan
 ‘Juan’s book’
 b. sus libros (*de los niños)
 their books of the boys
 ‘the boys’ books’
- (22) a. su libro (de usted)
 your book of you
 ‘your (formal) book’
 b. sus libros (de ustedes)
 your.PL books of you.PL
 ‘your (formal) books’
- (23) a. su libro (del señor)
 his book of the lord
 ‘Sir’s book’
 b. sus libros (de los señores)
 their books of the lords
 ‘Sirs’ books’

It is, nevertheless, possible for third-person pronouns and nominal expressions to occur in this construction in Andean, Central American, and Mexican Spanish, as shown by the examples in (24) and (25) that are cited in the *Nueva gramática de la lengua española* (Real Academia Española 2009: 1358).

- (24) a. Porque él deseaba tener un hijo varón justamente para que
because he desired.IMPF have a child male precisely for that
siguiera sus ideales de él y continuara su trabajo
follow.SBJV.IMPF his ideals of him and continue.SBJV.IMPF his work
de él.
of him
'Because he wanted to have a son precisely so that [the son] would follow
his ideals and continue his work.'
- b. Mi mamá no debía llamarse Inés Melgarejo, porque el
my mom not should.IMPF call.3 Inés Melgarejo because the
Melgarejo era apellido de su mamá de ella.
Melgarejo was surname of her mom of her
'My mom should not have been called Inés Melgarejo because Melgarejo
was her mom's family name.'
- (25) a. O sea que su mano de don Esteban toca bonito.
or is.SBJV that his hand of don Esteban plays pretty
'That is, Don Esteban's hand plays well.'
- b. Tocó la puerta y salió su mamá de la señorita.
touched.3SG the door and came.out.3SG her mom of the woman.DIM
'He/She knocked at the door, and the young woman's mother came out.'

In other words, the distinction that is found in Peninsular Spanish is absent in these other varieties. Instead, it seems that a postnominal stressed pronoun is included to disambiguate the intended referent of the prenominal possessive determiners *su* and *sus*, which can either be a participant or a nonparticipant in the discourse. The essential point is that this environment does not reliably differentiate *usted* and *ustedes* from other pronouns across all varieties of Spanish.

In summary, Collins and Ordóñez's (2021) proposal that *usted* 'you (formal)' and *ustedes* 'you all' are imposters faces numerous challenges that diminish its viability.⁷ Depending on the phenomenon under consideration, there are pragmatic or syntactic factors that may explain why these pronouns can appear in contexts that other pronouns in Spanish cannot. For instance, a speaker may wish to soften a request by adding *usted* or *ustedes* after an imperative verb, and the insertion of these pronouns after an auxiliary verb or a noun in a possessive construction can serve to clarify what may otherwise be an ambiguous sentence. In sections 3 and 4, I present unequivocal evidence that *usted* and *ustedes* are genuine second-person pronouns, not third-person imposters, in contemporary Spanish.

⁷Collins and Kayne's (2023) account of the syncretism between second-person and third-person plural agreement morphology in Latin American Spanish is, by extension, compromised as well because it hinges on the notion that *ustedes* is an imposter.

3 The Person-Case Constraint

So far in this paper, certain judgments regarding *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ have been vague or differ from one variety of Spanish to another. For all remaining examples, the judgments are far clearer and reveal a stark contrast between these pronouns and imposters. The purpose of this section is to demonstrate through the Person-Case Constraint that *usted* and *ustedes* are second person in the narrow syntax.

In Spanish, dative clitics uniformly precede accusative clitics, and the Person-Case Constraint manifests as follows: if the dative clitic is third person, the accusative clitic must be third person as well (Bonet i Alsina 1991; Laenzlinger 1993; Bonet 1994, 1995; Anagnostopoulou 2003, 2005; Nevins 2007; Ormazabal and Romero 2007; Rezac 2011; Arregi and Nevins 2018). This restriction is illustrated by the possible continuations of the utterances in (26) and (27), where the second-person clitics *te* and *os* can occur in dative position but not in accusative position because there is a third-person clitic in the same verbal complex.⁸

- (26) Inés, ¿reconoces a los lingüistas de Canadá?
 Inés recognize.2SG DOM the linguists from Canada
 ‘Inés, do you (informal) recognize the linguists from Canada?’
- a. Te los presenté en el último congreso.
 2SG 3PL.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced them to you (informal) at the last conference.’
- b. *Les te presenté en el último congreso.
 3PL.DAT 2SG presented.1SG in the last conference
 Intended: ‘I introduced you (informal) to them at the last conference.’
- (27) Inés y Julia, ¿reconocéis al lingüista de Canadá?
 Inés and Julia recognize.2PL DOM.the linguist from Canada
 ‘Inés and Julia, do you (informal) recognize the linguist from Canada?’
- a. Os lo presenté en el último congreso.
 2PL 3SG.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced him to you (informal) at the last conference.’
- b. *Le os presenté en el último congreso.
 3SG.DAT 2PL presented.1SG in the last conference
 Intended: ‘I introduced you (informal) to him at the last conference.’

The next step is to verify that two third-person clitics can appear in either order in Spanish, and to do so, I have made each question about a third party in (28) and (29).

- (28) ¿Inés reconoce a los lingüistas de Canadá?
 Inés recognizes DOM the linguists from Canada
 ‘Does Inés recognize the linguists from Canada?’

⁸Even if one replaces *les* in (26b) and *le* in (27b) with *se*, the form that third-person dative clitics take in the presence of a third-person accusative clitic in Spanish, the ungrammaticality persists: **se te presenté en el último congreso* ‘I introduced you (informal) to them in the last conference’ and **se os presenté en el último congreso* ‘I introduced you (informal) to him in the last conference’.

- a. Se los presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3PL.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced them to her at the last conference.’
- b. Se la presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3SG.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced her to them at the last conference.’
- (29) ¿Inés y Julia reconocen al lingüista de Canadá?
 Inés and Julia recognize.3PL DOM.the linguist from Canada
 ‘Do Inés and Julia recognize the linguist from Canada?’
- a. Se lo presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3SG.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced him to them at the last conference.’
- b. Se las presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3PL.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced them to him at the last conference.’

Having established that second-person and third-person arguments differ in their sensitivity to the Person-Case Constraint, it is now possible to examine the behavior of *usted* ‘you (formal)’, *ustedes* ‘you all’, and imposters in Spanish.

If, as Collins and Ordóñez (2021) maintain, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are syntactically third person, any clitics that are coreferential with these pronouns should be immune to the Person-Case Constraint, meaning that they can occur in accusative or dative position. This prediction is not borne out in (30) or (31), where the relevant clitic must occupy the dative position for each continuation to be felicitous (Jambrović 2025, to appear).⁹

- (30) Doctora Melgarejo, ¿usted reconoce a los lingüistas de Canadá?
 Dr. Melgarejo you recognizes DOM the linguists from Canada
 ‘Dr. Melgarejo, do you (formal) recognize the linguists from Canada?’
- a. Se los presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3PL.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 ‘I introduced them to you (formal) at the last conference.’
- b. #Se la presenté en el último congreso.
 3 3SG.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
 Intended: ‘I introduced you (formal) to them at the last conference.’
- (31) Doctora Melgarejo y doctora Ruiz, ¿ustedes reconocen al
 Dr. Melgarejo and Dr. Ruiz you.PL recognize.3PL DOM.the
 lingüista de Canadá?
 linguist from Canada
 ‘Dr. Melgarejo and Dr. Ruiz, do you recognize the linguist from Canada?’

⁹Rezac (2011) is, to my knowledge, the first to observe that the Person-Case Constraint applies to *usted* but still considers this pronoun to be syntactically third person. More recently, Adamson and Zoppi (to appear) have noted the same effect in Italian with *Lei* ‘you (formal)’.

- a. Se lo presenté en el último congreso.
3 3SG.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘I introduced him to you at the last conference.’
- b. #Se las presenté en el último congreso.
3 3PL.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
Intended: ‘I introduced you to him at the last conference.’

This restriction suggests that *usted* and *ustedes* are syntactically second person, like *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros/vosotras* ‘you all (informal)’, and that the use of third-person clitics with these pronouns is a surface phenomenon that stems from some type of postsyntactic operation.

Turning to imposters, I start with the observation that they are most naturally used with pronouns that correspond to their interpretation rather than to their form. For example, the imposter *la señora* ‘Madam’ in (32) could be followed by *usted* ‘you (formal)’ or *ella* ‘she, her’, but speakers would likely opt for *usted*, or no pronoun at all, unless the intention is to convey an exceptional level of formality.

- (32) Veo que la señora tiene una cita para un masaje hoy.
see.1SG that the lady has an appointment for a massage today
‘I see that Madam has an appointment for a massage today.’
- a. ¿A usted le interesaría un tratamiento facial también?
to you 3SG.DAT interest.COND a treatment facial also
‘Would you (formal) be interested in a facial treatment as well?’
- b. ¿A ella le interesaría un tratamiento facial también?
to her 3SG.DAT interest.COND a treatment facial also
‘Would she be interested in a facial treatment as well?’

It is essential to keep this preference in mind when assessing whether the imposter in (33) gives rise to a Person-Case Constraint effect.

- (33) ¿La señora reconoce a los lingüistas de Canadá?
the lady recognizes DOM the linguists from Canada
‘Does Madam recognize the linguists from Canada?’
- a. Se los presenté en el último congreso.
3 3PL.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘I introduced them to you (formal) at the last conference.’
‘I introduced them to her at the last conference.’
- b. Se la presenté en el último congreso.
3 3SG.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘I introduced her to them at the last conference.’
Unavailable: ‘I introduced you (formal) to them at the last conference.’

One might initially find the second continuation to be infelicitous because there is a strong tendency to interpret the accusative clitic *la* as doubling a silent *usted*, but as

the identical sentence in (30b) above shows, *la* cannot have a second-person reading in this configuration. This sentence is, however, felicitous if one takes *la* to double a silent *ella*, and the same consideration applies to the accusative clitic *las* in (34).

- (34) ¿Las señoras reconocen al lingüista de Canadá?
the ladies recognize.3PL DOM.the linguist from Canada
‘Do Madams recognize the linguist from Canada?’
- a. Se lo presenté en el último congreso.
3 3SG.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘I introduced him to you at the last conference.’
‘I introduced him to them at the last conference.’
- b. Se las presenté en el último congreso.
3 3PL.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘I introduced them to him at the last conference.’
Unavailable: ‘I introduced you to him at the last conference.’

In section 5, I defend the view that nonpronominal expressions are underspecified for person, and from this perspective, the referential flexibility of imposters is less surprising than it may otherwise seem.

The findings of this section can be summarized in a single data set, one that indicates the types of expressions that can serve as the antecedent of a third-person accusative clitic in the context of a third-person dative clitic. As illustrated in (35), third-person pronouns and imposters can be coreferential with a third-person accusative clitic, but *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ cannot.

- (35) a. ¿{Ella / La señora / #Usted} reconoce a los lingüistas de
she the lady you recognizes DOM the linguists from
Canadá? Se la presenté en el último congreso.
Canada 3 3SG.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘Does she/Madam recognize the linguists from Canada? I introduced her
to them at the last conference.’
- b. ¿{Ellas / Las señoras / #Ustedes} reconocen al lingüista
they.F the ladies you.PL recognize.3PL DOM.the linguist
de Canadá? Se las presenté en el último congreso.
from Canada 3 3PL.F.ACC presented.1SG in the last conference
‘Do they (feminine)/Madams recognize the linguist from Canada? I
introduced them to him at the last conference.’

These facts refute the possibility that *usted* and *ustedes* are syntactically third person, as in Collins and Ordóñez’s (2021) account. A further issue with their imposter-based analysis is that *usted* is posited to be the head of the noun phrase, but as I demonstrate in the next section, both *usted* and *ustedes* can appear in pronoun-noun constructions and are therefore generated in a higher position.

4 Pronoun-noun constructions

In many languages, first-person and second-person pronouns can be directly followed by a noun, but third-person pronouns cannot (Postal 1966; Abney 1987; Cardinaletti 1994; Lyons 1999; Déchaine and Wiltschko 2002; Giusti 2002; Panagiotidis 2002; Roehrs 2005; Bernstein 2008a,b; Höhn 2016, 2017; Ackema and Neeleman 2018; Höhn 2020). This restriction is shown in (36) and (37) with examples from English and Italian, respectively.

- (36) a. We linguists found a solution.
 b. You linguists found a solution.
 c. *They linguists found a solution.
- (37) a. Noi linguisti abbiamo trovato una soluzione.
 we linguists have.1PL found a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
 b. Voi linguisti avete trovato una soluzione.
 you.PL linguists have.2PL found a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’
 c. *Loro linguisti hanno trovato una soluzione.
 they linguists have.3PL found a solution
 Literal: ‘They linguists found a solution.’

In Spanish, the definite article must intervene between the pronoun and the noun, as in *nosotros* **(los) lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’, but this language otherwise displays the same paradigmatic gap in (38) through (40).

- (38) a. Nosotros los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
 we the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
 b. Nosotras las lingüistas encontramos una solución.
 we.F the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We (feminine) linguists found a solution.’
- (39) a. Vosotros los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
 you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
 ‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’
 b. Vosotras las lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
 you.F.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
 ‘You (informal, feminine) linguists found a solution.’
- (40) a. *Ellos los lingüistas encontraron una solución.
 they the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘They the linguists found a solution.’

- b. **Ellas las lingüistas encontraron una solución.*
 they.F the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘They (feminine) the linguists found a solution.’

In this section, I show that these types of constructions provide further evidence that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are syntactically second person and address the question of why pronouns are able to cooccur with the definite article in Spanish.

Continuing with the plural paradigm for the moment, the data in (41) illustrate that *ustedes* ‘you all’ readily appears in pronoun-noun constructions (Jambrović 2025, to appear).¹⁰

- (41) a. *Ustedes los lingüistas encontraron una solución.*
 you.PL the linguists found.3PL a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’
 b. *Ustedes las lingüistas encontraron una solución.*
 you.PL the linguists found.3PL a solution
 ‘You (feminine) linguists found a solution.’

In this way, *ustedes* patterns like *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ in (39) rather than *ellos* ‘they’ in (40) or the imposters in (42).

- (42) a. **Los señores los lingüistas encontraron una solución.*
 the gentlemen the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘The gentlemen the linguists found a solution.’
 b. **Las señoras las lingüistas encontraron una solución.*
 the ladies the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘The ladies the linguists found a solution.’

The contrast between *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ and **los señores los lingüistas* ‘the gentlemen the linguists’ echoes the finding based on the Person-Case Constraint that *ustedes* behaves like a second-person pronoun and that imposters behave like third-person pronouns.

Singular pronoun-noun constructions are less common than plural ones but are nonetheless possible in Spanish, especially in a context like (43) where they serve to highlight a difference between individuals (Jambrović 2025).

- (43) *Yo el lingüista tengo otra perspectiva que tú el filósofo.*
 I the linguist have.1SG other perspective than you the philosopher
 Literal: ‘I the linguist have a different perspective than you (informal) the philosopher.’

The facts in (44) confirm that *usted* ‘you (formal)’, singular third-person pronouns, and singular imposters mirror their plural counterparts in that *usted* is grammatical in this environment and the other expressions are not.

¹⁰Although the term “pronoun-article-noun construction” would be more accurate for Spanish, I use “pronoun-noun construction” for convenience.

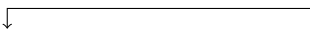
- (44) a. Yo el lingüista tengo otra perspectiva que {tú / vos / usted /
I the linguist have.1SG other perspective than you you you
*él / *el señor} el filósofo.
he the gentleman the philosopher
Literal: ‘I the linguist have a different perspective than you (informal)/you (informal)/you (formal) the philosopher.’
- b. Yo la lingüista tengo otra perspectiva que {tú / vos / usted /
I the linguist have.1SG other perspective than you you you
*ella / *la señora} la filósofa.
she the lady the philosopher
Literal: ‘I (feminine) the linguist have a different perspective than you (informal, feminine)/you (informal, feminine)/you (formal, feminine) the philosopher.’

I now turn to the issue of where first-person and second-person pronouns, including *usted* and *ustedes*, originate in the structure of the noun phrase.

In recent crosslinguistic work, Choi (2013, 2014a,b) and Höhn (2016, 2017) draw a connection between the use of the definite article in pronoun-noun constructions and the possibility of “unagreement”. This phenomenon is shown in (45), where the nonpronominal subject *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’ appears with first-person and second-person verb forms (Moravcsik 1978, Jelinek 1984, Hurtado 1985, Torrego 1996, Ordóñez 1997, Fernández Soriano 1999, Ordóñez and Treviño 1999, Villa-García 2010, Saab 2013, Torrego and Laka 2015, Ackema and Neeleman 2018, Di Tullio et al. 2019).

- (45) a. Los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
the linguists found.1PL a solution
Approximate: ‘We linguists found a solution.’
- b. Los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
the linguists found.2PL a solution
Approximate: ‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

Choi and Höhn both observe that such sentences permit the addition of a pronoun before the definite description, as in (46), which results in a pronoun-noun construction that makes the source of first-person or second-person agreement evident.

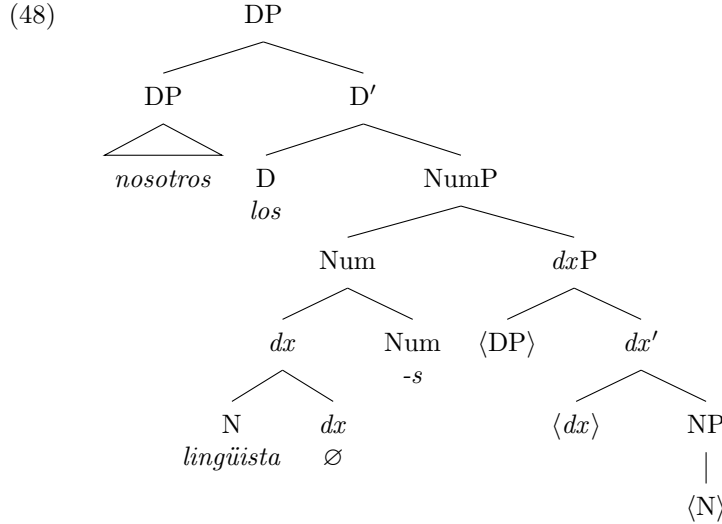
- (46) a.  Nosotros los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
we the linguists found.1PL a solution
‘We linguists found a solution.’
- b.  Vosotros los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

Given that Spanish is a pro-drop language, all that is needed to explain the apparent cases of unagreement in (45) is to posit standard agreement with an unpronounced first-person or second-person pronoun, as in (47).

- (47) a. $\emptyset_{[\pi:\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}$ los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
 we the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
- b. $\emptyset_{[\pi:\text{PART}]}$ los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
 you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
 ‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

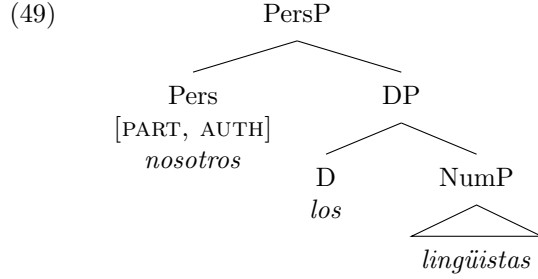
In other words, definite descriptions that occur with first-person or second-person agreement morphology in Spanish are simply covert pronoun-noun constructions, which is why Höhn considers the term “unagreement” to be a misnomer.

Where Choi (2013, 2014a,b) and Höhn (2016, 2017) differ in their analyses relates to the base-generation position of pronouns. For Choi, they enter the derivation as specifiers of a deixis phrase (dxP) and then raise to the specifier of DP, as schematized in (48) with *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’.



For Höhn, there is no universal position in which pronouns originate. In languages like Spanish that require the definite article in pronoun-noun constructions and permit unagreement, pronouns realize the head of a person phrase (PersP) that dominates DP, as in (49).¹¹

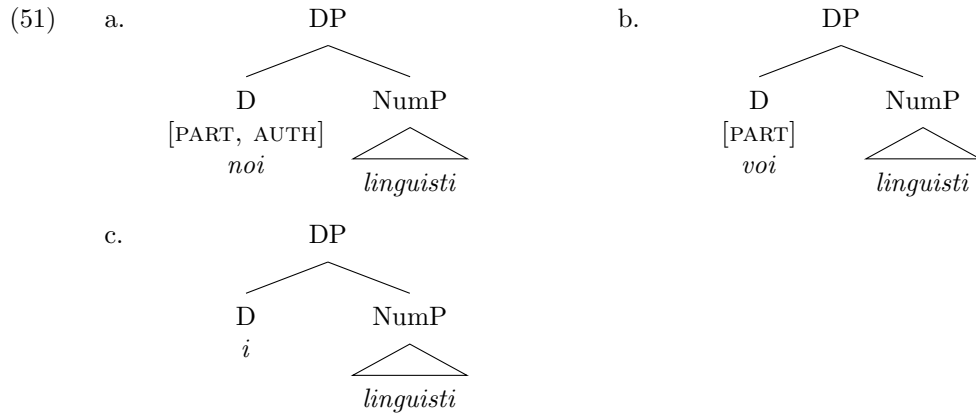
¹¹This structure, like Platzack’s (2004) original implementation of PersP, is consistent with Ritter’s (1995: 421) claim that “person implies definiteness, but definiteness does not imply person”.



In languages like Italian that reject the definite article in pronoun-noun constructions and disallow unagreement, as indicated in (50), there is no PersP.

- (50) a. Noi (*i) linguisti abbiamo trovato una soluzione.
 we the linguists have.1PL found a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
 b. I linguisti {hanno / *abbiamo} trovato una soluzione.
 the linguists have.3PL have.1PL found a solution
 ‘The linguists found a solution.’

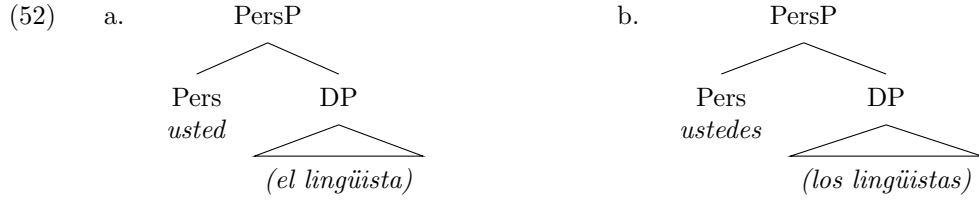
Instead, pronouns compete with the definite article for D, as illustrated by the featural configurations that correspond to *noi linguisti* ‘we linguists’, *voi linguisti* ‘you linguists’, and *i linguisti* ‘the linguists’ in (51).



That is, D in Italian can either be realized as a pronoun, yielding a pronoun-noun construction, or as the definite article, yielding a definite description. In this paper, I adopt Höhn’s proposal rather than Choi’s because the former more elegantly captures the fact that some languages employ the definite article in pronoun-noun constructions and others do not.

Earlier in this section, I demonstrated that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ pattern like first-person and second-person pronouns in that they can immediately precede a definite description: *usted el lingüista* ‘you (formal) the linguist’ and *ustedes*

los lingüistas ‘you the linguists’. There is, consequently, empirical rationale to assign these pronouns to Pers, as in (52), whose DP complement can be overt or covert.



According to this view, *usted el lingüista* and *ustedes los lingüistas* constitute a single extended nominal projection that contains two determiners, similar to *todos los lingüistas* ‘all the linguists’. In these pronoun-noun constructions, N cannot be the position in which *usted* enters the derivation, as in Collins and Ordóñez’s (2021) imposter-based approach, because it is already filled by *lingüista* ‘linguist’. It is indisputable that *usted* and *ustedes* have nominal origins, but there is no synchronic evidence to suggest that any part of these pronouns still occupies the lexical layer of the noun phrase.

To review the findings so far, the Person-Case Constraint reveals that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are syntactically second person, and pronoun-noun constructions confirm that these forms are generated in the same functional head as other pronouns in Spanish. One major problem remains, however, which is how to account for the realization of Pers as *usted* or *ustedes* and not as another second-person pronoun. In section 5, I discuss my theoretical assumptions regarding person features, and in section 6, I argue in favor of a dedicated [HON(ORIFIC)] feature.

5 The representation of person features

In my analysis of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, I subscribe to the model of Distributed Morphology in Figure 1, where the roots and morphosyntactic features of List 1 are assembled into structures that are transferred to morphological operations and logical form along separate paths, the vocabulary items of List 2 relate phonological strings to the environment in which they are inserted, and the encyclopedia entries of List 3 pair vocabulary items with their contextually dependent “meanings” (Halle and Marantz 1993, 1994; Marantz 1996; Halle 1997; Marantz 1997; Harley and Noyer 1999; Embick and Noyer 2001; Marantz 2001; Arad 2003, 2005; Embick and Noyer 2007; Embick and Marantz 2008; Embick 2010; Marantz 2013; Embick 2015).

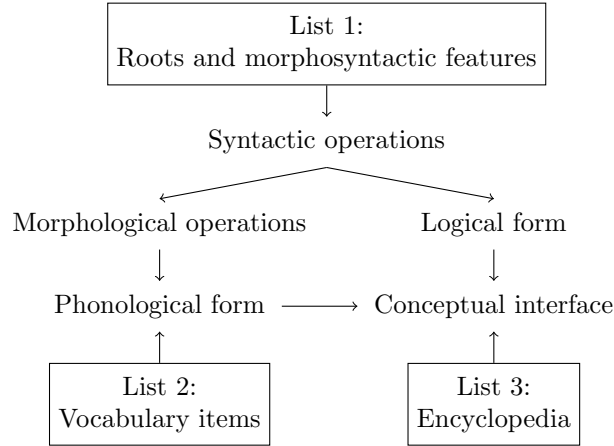


Figure 1 Distributed Morphology

The objective of this section is to formalize the system of person features that I will use to represent *usted* and *ustedes* as these pronouns move through the various modules of the grammar.

I start with the question of whether third person is distinct from the absence of person and take the answer to be affirmative based on the contrast that Ackema and Neeleman (2013b: 307–308, 2018: 53–54) identify in (53) versus (54), where the underlined expressions are intended to be coreferential.

- (53) a. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes we no longer wear wooden shoes.
 b. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes you no longer wear wooden shoes.
 c. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes they no longer wear wooden shoes.
- (54) a. *Anyone who knows them realizes we no longer wear wooden shoes.
 b. *Anyone who knows them realizes you no longer wear wooden shoes.
 c. Anyone who knows them realizes they no longer wear wooden shoes.

In the first data set, the definite description *the Dutch* does not produce a referential clash with a first-person or second-person pronoun, while in the second data set, the third-person pronoun *them* does, and this difference suggests that nonpronominal arguments do not bear person features. The same judgments hold for the Spanish translations of these examples in (55) and (56), where I use parentheses to indicate that the pronominal subject of each subordinate clause can be dropped.

- (55) a. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (nosotros) ya no llevamos zuecos de madera.
 account of that we already not wear.1PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that we no longer wear wooden shoes.’

- b. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (vosotros) ya no lleváis zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.2PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that you all (informal) no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- c. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (ustedes) ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that you all no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- d. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (ellos) ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that they already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that they no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- (56) a. *Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (nosotros) ya no llevamos zuecos de madera.
 account of that we already not wear.1PL clogs of wood
 Literal: ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that we no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- b. *Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (vosotros) ya no lleváis zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.2PL clogs of wood
 Literal: ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that you all (informal) no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- c. *Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (ustedes) ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 Literal: ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that you all no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- d. Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que (ellos) ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that they already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that they no longer wear wooden shoes.’

The contrast between nonpronominal and third-person expressions can be illustrated more concisely in Spanish by embedding the relevant constituents in prepositional phrases, as in (57), which in turn requires them to be overt.

- (57) a. Cualquiera que hable con los holandeses se acordará
 anyone that speaks.SBJV with the Dutch 3 remember.FUT.3SG
 de {nosotros / vosotros / ustedes / ellos}.
 of us you.PL you.PL them
 ‘Anyone who speaks with the Dutch will remember us/you all (informal)/you all/them.’
- b. Cualquiera que hable con ellos se acordará de
 anyone that speaks.SBJV with them 3 remember.FUT.3SG of
 {*nosotros / *vosotros / *ustedes / ellos}.
 us you.PL you.PL them
 ‘Anyone who speaks with them will remember them.’

The fact that Spanish allows definite descriptions to appear with first-person and second-person verb forms, as shown in section 4 through examples like *los lingüistas encontramos una solución* ‘we linguists found a solution’ and *los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución* ‘you (informal) linguists found a solution’, bolsters the claim that nonpronominal arguments are underspecified for person.

In a privative approach to the representation of person features, [PART(ICIPANT)] and [AUTH(OR)] alone are insufficient to differentiate third person from the lack of person. The system in (58) resolves this issue by incorporating Béjar’s (2003) π feature to establish a natural class of person-marked expressions (Sichel and Wiltschko 2021; Toosarvandani 2023; Alexiadou et al. 2024; Jambrović 2025, to appear; Sichel and Toosarvandani to appear).¹²

- (58) a. [π , PART, AUTH] First person
 b. [π , PART] Second person
 c. [π] Third person
 d. [] No person

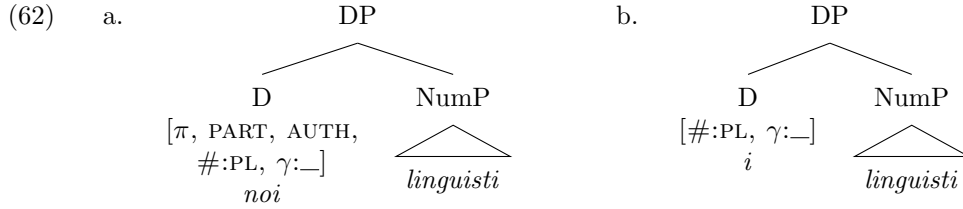
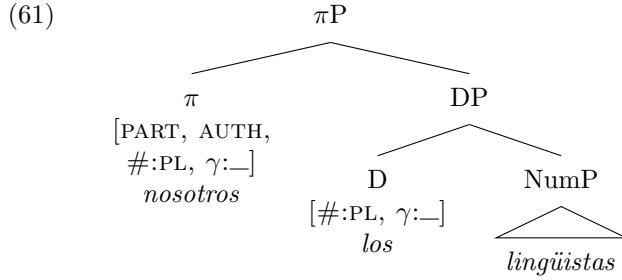
Combining this notation with Höhn’s (2016, 2017) insight that the locus of person features varies from one language to another results in the structures in (59) for Spanish and those in (60) for Italian, where the use of π P rather than PersP more transparently reflects the notion that person features can head their own functional projection or be hosted by D.

- (59) Spanish
- a. [π P_[PART, AUTH] [DP]] First person
 b. [π P_[PART] [DP]] Second person
 c. [π P [DP]] Third person
 d. [DP] No person

¹²Ackema and Neeleman (2013a, 2018) make this distinction as well but use the iterative features [PROX(IMATE)] and [DIST(AL)].

- (60) Italian
- | | | |
|----|--|---------------|
| a. | [DP] _[π, PART, AUTH] | First person |
| b. | [DP] _[π, PART] | Second person |
| c. | [DP] _[π] | Third person |
| d. | [DP] | No person |

For example, *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’ in Spanish can be represented as in (61), and *noi linguisti* ‘we linguists’ and *i linguisti* ‘the linguists’ in Italian can be represented as in (62).¹³



As mentioned in section 4, *noi* ‘we’ and *i* ‘the’ are in complementary distribution in Italian because D cannot be spelled out as a pronoun and the definite article in the same noun phrase.

The next topic to explore is the person specification of what is often classified as third-person agreement morphology. In (63), where the same verb form appears with the third-person pronoun *ellos* ‘they’ and the personless definite description *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’, the question is how to represent the verb ending *-n* as a vocabulary item.

- (63) a. Ellos encontraron una solución.
 they found.3PL a solution
 ‘They found a solution.’

¹³Here and in all morphosyntactic configurations that follow, # and γ designate number and gender concord, and — means that an expression is underspecified for that feature. Masculine gender is the morphological default in Spanish and Italian, unlike plural number, so I do not consider *lingüistas* ‘linguists’ or *linguisti* ‘linguists’ to bear a [M(ASCULINE)] feature. Instead, the occurrence of “masculine” forms like *nosotros* ‘we’ and *los* ‘the’ in (61) and *i* ‘the’ in (62b) can be attributed to failed concord, just as Preminger (2009, 2014) argues that there can be failed agreement.

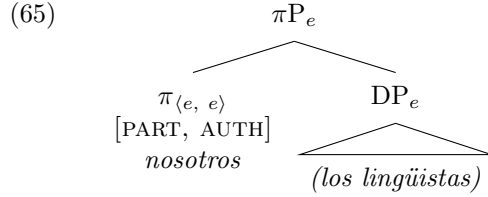
- b. Los lingüistas encontraron una solución.
 the linguists found.3PL a solution
 ‘The linguists found a solution.’

Given the ungrammaticality of **ellos los lingüistas* ‘they the linguists’ in (40a) above, there is no empirical basis to posit a covert third-person pronoun in (63b) that would serve as a goal for agreement. For this reason, I maintain that *-n* is underspecified for person, unlike first-person *-mos* and second-person *-is*, as indicated by the vocabulary items in (64).¹⁴

- (64) a. /mos/ $\leftrightarrow$ T_[π :AUTH, #:PL]
 b. /is/ $\leftrightarrow$ T_[π :PART, #:PL]
 c. /n/ $\leftrightarrow$ T_[#:PL]

Halle’s (1997) Subset Principle states that vocabulary items can be underspecified but not overspecified with respect to the context of insertion, so *-n* will be used regardless of whether the subject is third person, like *ellos*, or unmarked for person, like *los lingüistas*. More broadly, this discussion of verb endings supports the following generalization: arguments can be first person, second person, third person, or personless, but agreement morphology can only be first person, second person, or personless.

I close this section by addressing the semantics of person features. Considering that definite descriptions and pronouns are both individual-denoting, or type *e*, expressions, π must be a partial or total identity function of type $\langle e, e \rangle$, as illustrated by the interpretable structure of *nosotros (los lingüistas)* ‘we (the linguists)’ in (65).



There is consensus that person features either presuppose or assert contextually dependent discourse roles like author and addressee, which can be abbreviated by Harbour’s (2016) labels *i* (“I”) and *u* (“you”), respectively (Heim and Kratzer 1998, Sauerland 2003, Heim 2008, Sauerland 2008, Bobaljik and Sauerland 2023, Toosarvandani 2023, Alexiadou et al. 2024, Deal to appear, Sichel and Toosarvandani to appear). I present the mechanics of the presupposition-based view because it has a longer tradition in the literature, but the analysis of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ that I develop in this article is likewise compatible with assertion-based view that Bobaljik and Sauerland (2023) and Alexiadou et al. (2024) defend.

¹⁴I use T to remain theory neutral, but see Oltra-Massuet and Arregi 2005 for the proposal that verb endings are inserted into an Agr node that is added to T as part of a postsyntactic morphological operation.

According to the lexical entries in (66), [PART] presupposes that the author (i) or the addressee (u) of the discourse context (c) is a part of ($\leq$) individual x , [AUTH] presupposes that the author is a part of x , and $[\pi]$ is semantically vacuous.¹⁵

- (66) a. $\llbracket[\text{PART}]\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x . x$
 b. $\llbracket[\text{AUTH}]\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x$
 c. $\llbracket[\pi]\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e . x$

The combination of these features yields the correct denotation for first-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}$ once the presuppositions of [PART] and [AUTH] have been coordinated and simplified, as in (67).

- (67) $\llbracket\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : [i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x] \wedge i_c \leq x . x$
 $= \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x$

As for second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$, Deal (to appear) identifies a straightforward way of excluding $i_c \leq x$ from its semantic value. Since $\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}$ presupposes that $i_c \leq x$, $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ can be argued to presuppose $u_c \leq x$ due to a competition principle like Heim’s (1991) Maximize Presupposition, as detailed in (68).

- (68) $\llbracket\pi_{[\text{PART}]}\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x . x$, which strengthens to
 $\lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x$, given that $\llbracket\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}\rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x$

With this theoretical background in place, I now return to the issue of how π comes to be spelled out as *usted* ‘you (formal)’ or *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish.

6 Morphological and semantic impoverishment

As mentioned in the introduction, some languages obtain formal pronouns from nominal expressions, while others recruit existing pronouns for this purpose. In recent work that focuses primarily on the second process, Wang (2023) finds that languages predictably “recycle” pronouns that bear semantically unmarked features like third person and plural.¹⁶ For instance, *Sie* ‘you (formal), you all (formal)’ in German is derived from third-person plural *sie* ‘they’, which is less semantically marked than second-person singular *du* ‘you (informal)’ and second-person plural *ihr* ‘you all (informal)’ in terms of person, and *vous* ‘you (formal)’ in French is derived from second-person plural *vous* ‘you all’, which is less semantically marked than second-person singular *tu* ‘you (informal)’ in terms of number. In light of this tendency, Wang (2023: 1315) proposes that a morphosyntactic feature like [HON(ORIFIC)] can be abandoned in favor of the pragmatic maxim in (69).

- (69) *Taboo of Directness* (ToD):
 In respect contexts, use the form with the weakest presupposition.

¹⁵Another possibility, though one that remains to be formalized, is that $[\pi]$ itself contributes the “potential” to be a discourse participant (Sichel and Wiltschko 2021, Toosarvandani 2023, Sichel and Toosarvandani to appear).

¹⁶Sauerland (2008) demonstrates through a crosslinguistic exploration of φ -features that semantic markedness is distinct from morphological markedness.

In this section, I contend that [HON] is vital to the analysis of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, not only to distinguish these pronouns as vocabulary items but also to capture their unique semantic and syntactic properties.

No matter the variety of Spanish under study, the inventory of stressed pronouns cannot be organized into one form per cell with person, number, and gender as the only dimensions. As shown with the subject pronouns of Peninsular Spanish in Table 1, *tú* ‘you (informal)’ and *usted* ‘you (formal)’ occupy the same cell, as do *vosotros/vosotras* ‘you all (informal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’.¹⁷

Table 1 Subject pronouns of Peninsular Spanish

Person	Gender	Number					
		Singular			Plural		
First	Masculine				<i>nosotros</i>		
	Feminine	<i>yo</i>			<i>nosotras</i>		
Second	Masculine	<i>tú</i>	–	<i>usted</i>	<i>vosotros</i>	–	<i>ustedes</i>
	Feminine				<i>vosotras</i>		
Third	Masculine	<i>él</i>			<i>ellos</i>		
	Feminine	<i>ella</i>			<i>ellas</i>		

The same observation applies to the subject pronouns of Latin American Spanish in Table 2, where *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ share a cell with *usted*.

Table 2 Subject pronouns of Latin American Spanish

Person	Gender	Number					
		Singular			Plural		
First	Masculine				<i>nosotros</i>		
	Feminine	<i>yo</i>			<i>nosotras</i>		
Second	Masculine	<i>tú/vos</i>	–	<i>usted</i>	<i>ustedes</i>		
	Feminine						
Third	Masculine	<i>él</i>			<i>ellos</i>		
	Feminine	<i>ella</i>			<i>ellas</i>		

The only way for every form to be uniquely identifiable is to introduce the notion of formality, as in Tables 3 and 4.

¹⁷The distinction between Peninsular and Latin American Spanish in Tables 1 through 4 abstracts away from the fact that there are a few regions of Spain, namely western Andalusia and the Canary Islands, that do not use *vosotros/vosotras*. My account of *ustedes* in Latin American Spanish can be extended to these varieties as well.

Table 3 Subject pronouns of Peninsular Spanish, revised

Person	Formality	Gender	Number	
			Singular	Plural
First		Masculine		<i>nosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>yo</i>	<i>nosotras</i>
Second	Informal	Masculine		<i>vosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>tú</i>	<i>vosotras</i>
	Formal	Masculine		
		Feminine	<i>usted</i>	<i>ustedes</i>
Third		Masculine	<i>él</i>	<i>ellos</i>
		Feminine	<i>ella</i>	<i>ellas</i>

Table 4 Subject pronouns of Latin American Spanish, revised

Person	Formality	Gender	Number	
			Singular	Plural
First		Masculine		<i>nosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>yo</i>	<i>nosotras</i>
Second	Informal	Masculine		
		Feminine	<i>tú/vos</i>	
	Formal	Masculine		<i>ustedes</i>
		Feminine	<i>usted</i>	
Third		Masculine	<i>él</i>	<i>ellos</i>
		Feminine	<i>ella</i>	<i>ellas</i>

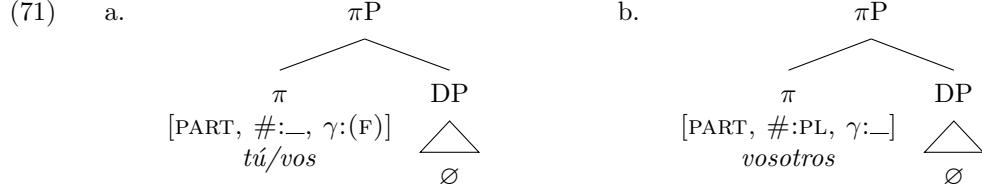
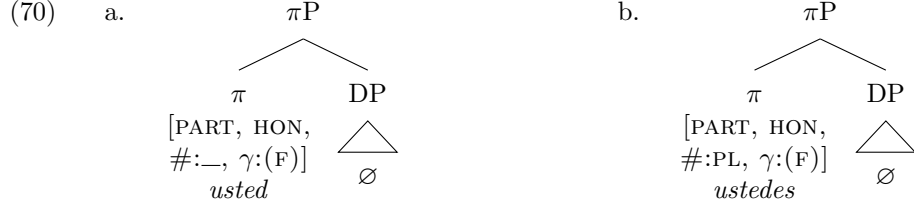
In short, there is empirical motivation for an [HON] feature in Spanish and other languages where formal pronouns evolved from nominal expressions.

Unlike Arregi and Nevins (2018), I take *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ to be the nondefault second-person pronouns of Spanish, and since nondefault forms are more specified than default forms, I posit that [HON] is what differentiates *usted* from *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *ustedes* from *vosotros/vosotras* ‘you all (informal)’. Accordingly, *usted* and *ustedes* have the representations in (70) at the level of syntax, and *tú/vos* and *vosotros* have the representations in (71).¹⁸

¹⁸Although *usted*, *ustedes*, and *tú/vos* do not overtly inflect for gender in the way that *vosotros/vosotras* do, they still have “masculine” and feminine guises, as does *yo* ‘I’. For instance, *usted* can occur with either form of the adjective *alto/alta* ‘tall’ in (i).

- (i) Usted es {alto / alta}.
 you is tall tall
 ‘You (formal) are tall.’

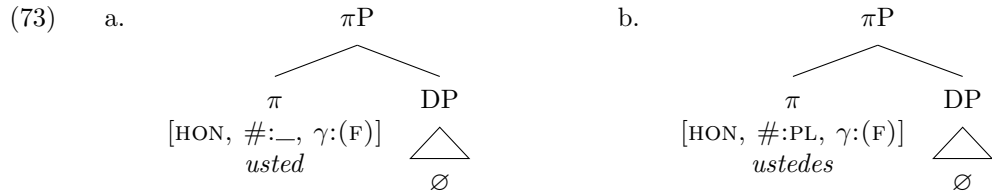
When these invariable pronouns trigger feminine agreement, they bear an [F] feature, and when they fail to do so, they are underspecified for gender, like *vosotros* in (71b).



One of the tenets of Distributed Morphology is that features can be eliminated post-syntactically through an operation known as impoverishment (Bonet i Alsina 1991; Halle and Marantz 1993; Bonet 1994; Halle and Marantz 1994; Bonet 1995; Harris 1995; Marantz 1996; Halle 1997; Harris 1998; Harley and Noyer 1999; Embick and Noyer 2007; Embick 2010, 2015). I argue that [PART] is one such feature and that [HON] is responsible for its deletion, as stated by the rule of impoverishment in (72).

(72) [PART] $\rightarrow$ $\emptyset$ / – [HON] Morphological operations

This process takes the syntactic structures of *usted* and *ustedes* in (70) and returns the morphosyntactic structures in (73).



Morphological operations like impoverishment precede lexical insertion, so the vocabulary items that pertain to *usted* and *ustedes* in (74) both lack [PART].

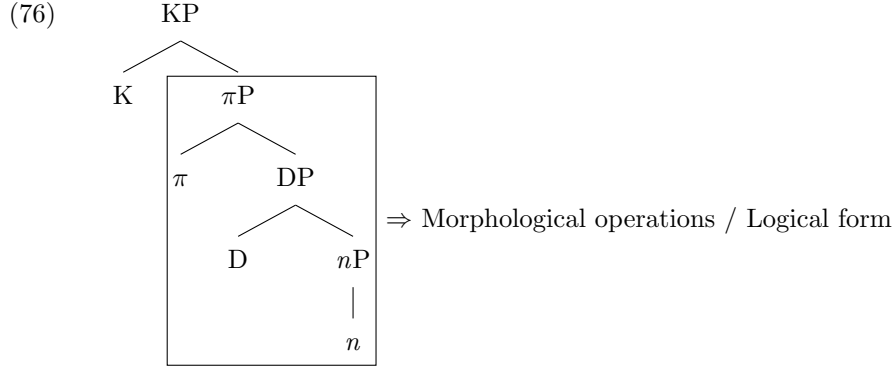
(74) a. /ustedes/ $\leftrightarrow$ $\pi_{[HON, \#:-PL]}$
 b. /usted/ $\leftrightarrow$ $\pi_{[HON]}$

In contrast, the vocabulary items that pertain to *tú/vos* and *vosotros/vosotras* in (75) do contain [PART] because these pronouns are exempt from the rule in (72).

(75) a. /bosotras/ $\leftrightarrow$ $\pi_{[PART, \#:-PL, \gamma:F]}$
 b. /bosotros/ $\leftrightarrow$ $\pi_{[PART, \#:-PL]}$
 c. /tu/ or /bos/ $\leftrightarrow$ $\pi_{[PART]}$

Without [HON], it would not be possible to formally distinguish *usted* from *tú/vos* or *ustedes* from *vosotros/vosotras* as realizations of π .

Beyond impoverishment, all that is needed to explain why *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ fail to establish second-person agreement is the assumption that π P is spelled out in a different cycle than verbs and clitics. If, following Bittner and Hale (1996a,b), the extended projection of the noun culminates in a case phrase (KP), and if, following Richards (2010), KP rather than DP constitutes a phase boundary, the merger of K in (76) will send its π P complement to the interfaces.



As a result, *usted* and *ustedes* lose their [PART] feature before the verb in (77a) or the clitic in (77b) enter the derivation, hence the use of default person morphology.

- (77)
- a. $\text{Usted}_{[\pi:\text{HON}, \#:\text{---}, \gamma:\text{F}]}$ es alta.
 you is tall
 ‘You (formal) are tall.’
- b. $\text{Los conozco a ustedes}_{[\pi:\text{HON}, \#:\text{PL}, \gamma:\text{---}]}$.
 3PL.ACC know.1SG DOM you.PL
 ‘I know you all.’

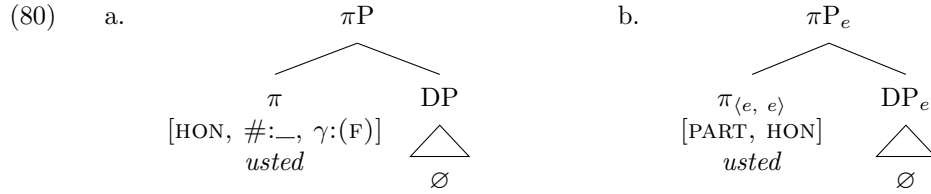
The syncretism between *usted* and *él/ella* ‘he/she’ in (78) and between *ustedes* and *ellos/ellas* ‘they’ in (79) has long been a topic of inquiry in Distributed Morphology, and all proposals to date have taken this phenomenon to be the outcome of impoverishment processes that apply to verb endings and clitics, or the probes for agreement (Halle and Marantz 1994; Harris 1995, 1998; Embick 2015; Arregi and Nevins 2018).

- (78)
- a. {Usted / Él / Ella} es lingüista.
 you he she is linguist
 ‘You (formal) are/He is/She is a linguist.’
- b. Lo conozco a {usted / él}.
 3SG.ACC know.1SG DOM you him
 ‘I know you (formal)/him.’

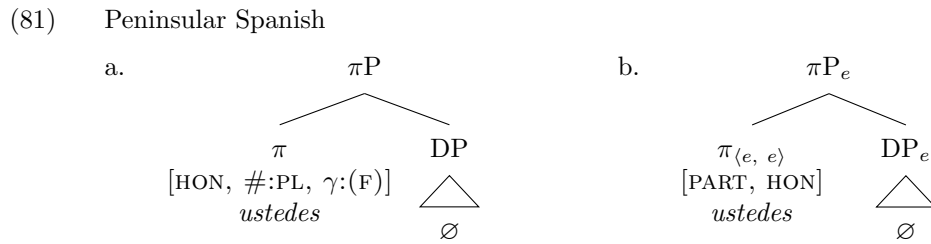
- c. La conozco a {usted / ella}.
 3SG.F.ACC know.1SG DOM you her
 ‘I know you (formal)/her.’
- (79) a. {Ustedes / Ellos / Ellas} son lingüistas.
 you.PL they they.F are.3PL linguists
 ‘You all/They/They (feminine) are linguists.’
- b. Los conozco a {ustedes / ellos}.
 3PL.ACC know.1SG DOM you.PL them
 ‘I know you all/them.’
- c. Las conozco a {ustedes / ellas}.
 3PL.F.ACC know.1SG DOM you.PL them.F
 ‘I know you all/them (feminine).’

My approach is simpler, and thus theoretically advantageous, in that it attributes these various instances of syncretism to a single rule of impoverishment, one that targets arguments themselves, or the goals for agreement.

Postsyntactic operations like impoverishment have no affect on logical form, so *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ retain their [PART] feature in this module of the grammar. There is, consequently, a mismatch between the absence of [PART] in the morphosyntactic structure of *usted* in (80a) and the presence of [PART] in its interpretable structure in (80b).



As these representations correctly predict for all varieties of Spanish, *usted* triggers third-person agreement, refers to the addressee, and conveys formality. The plural counterparts of these structures in (81) are likewise accurate for Peninsular Spanish, where *ustedes* triggers third-person agreement, refers to a group of individuals that includes the addressee, and conveys formality.

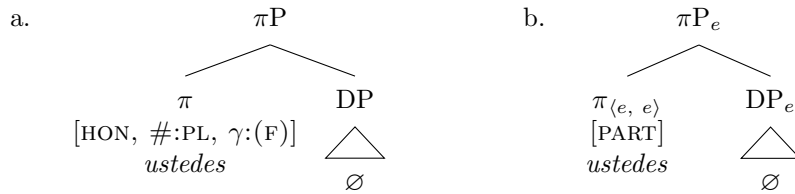


The situation is more complex with *ustedes* in Latin American Spanish, however, as this pronoun is the only plural form of address and does not necessarily convey formality. To account for this difference between Peninsular and Latin American Spanish, I propose the variety-specific rule of impoverishment at logical form in (82), according to which [HON] is deleted in the environment of [PL(URAL)].¹⁹

$$(82) \quad [\text{HON}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{PL}] \quad \text{Logical form (Latin American Spanish only)}$$

Independently of whether one considers Ritter’s (1991, 1992) NumP or Borer’s (2005) division phrase (DivP) to be the locus of number features, this process can be characterized as contextual allophony because the semantics of π is conditioned by a feature on another head that lies within the same cyclic domain. Recall from the syntactic structure of *ustedes* in (70b) above that this pronoun is generated with [PART] and [HON] features, and since *ustedes* is subject to morphological as well as semantic impoverishment in Latin American Spanish, it has the morphosyntactic structure in (83a), which contains [HON] but not [PART], and the interpretable structure in (83b), which contains [PART] but not [HON].

(83) Latin American Spanish



Even though *ustedes* does not express politeness in Latin American Spanish, it nevertheless maintains a transparent morphological relation to *usted*, one that would fail to be captured without the [HON] feature that is common to the vocabulary items in (74) and to π in (80a) and (83a).

To summarize the analysis, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ both originate with [PART] and [HON] features that are transferred to the interfaces. In all varieties of Spanish, [PART] is eliminated in the context of [HON] during morphological operations, which disables *usted* and *ustedes* from establishing second-person agreement. Moreover, in Latin American Spanish, [HON] is eliminated in the context of [PL] at logical form, so this feature does not factor into the interpretation of *ustedes*. Having defended the need for [HON] in languages like Spanish where formal pronouns are grammaticalized nominal expressions, I now address its denotation.

7 The semantics of [HON]

The aim of this penultimate section is to derive a lexical entry for [HON] such that this feature makes the same contribution in plural *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ in Peninsular

¹⁹The view that features can be eliminated at logical form has precedent in work on pronouns by Nevins (2008) and Ackema and Neeleman (2018).

Spanish that it does in singular *usted* ‘you (formal)’. To do so, I begin with the question of whether there can be more than one addressee per discourse context. One reason to suspect that addressee is a unique role is that there do not seem to be any languages that morphologically encode the distinction in (84), which is often described as homogeneous versus heterogeneous plurality (Zwicky 1977, Greenberg 1988, McGregor 1989, Greenberg 1993, Noyer 1997, Cysouw 2003, Daniel 2005, Simon 2005, Bobaljik 2008, Harbour 2016, Ackema and Neeleman 2018).

- (84) a. Homogeneous second-person plurality:
addressee + addressee (+ addressee ...)
- b. Heterogeneous second-person plurality:
addressee (+ addressee ...) + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)

That is, no language has one second-person pronoun for groups that consist of two or more addressees and another for groups that consist of at least one addressee and at least one nonparticipant. In the absence of evidence to suggest that the concept of multiple addressees is expressed by natural language, the representation of plural second-person reference can be simplified as in (85).

- (85) Extension of any plural second-person pronoun:
addressee + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)

As it turns out, this combination of discourse (non)roles is exactly what results from the application of second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ to a plural DP.

To illustrate this point, I use *vosotros los lingüistas* ‘you (informal) the linguists’ in Peninsular Spanish as well as *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ in Latin American Spanish since these pronoun-noun constructions have the same interpretable structure, as indicated in (86).

- (86) a. πP_e
- $\pi_{\langle e, e \rangle}$
[PART]
vosotros

DP_e
 $\triangle$
los lingüistas
- b. πP_e
- $\pi_{\langle e, e \rangle}$
[PART]
ustedes

DP_e
 $\triangle$
los lingüistas

First, the definite description *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’ has the semantic value in (87), where I assume that a maximality operator (MAX) is a component of definiteness (Montague 1973; Sharvy 1980; Link 1983, Krifka 1989; Landman 1989a,b; Chierchia 1998a,b; Zamparelli 1998, 2002; Bale and Barner 2009; Gillon 2009; Heim 2011; Champollion and Krifka 2016; Jambrović 2025).²⁰

²⁰Concretely, I adopt Heim’s (2011: 998) lexical entry for the definite article in (ia) and definition of a maximalized property, or $\text{MAX}(P)$, in (ib).

- (i) a. $\llbracket \text{the} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} : \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(P)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] . \iota x_e \text{MAX}(P)(x)$
b. $\text{MAX}(P) := \lambda x_e . P(x) \wedge \neg \exists y_e [P(y) \wedge x < y]$

$$(87) \quad \llbracket \text{los lingüistas} \rrbracket = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$$

In prose, *los lingüistas* denotes a unique maximal sum of individuals x that are linguists, and this expression is defined only if such a unique maximal sum of linguists exists. Second, *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ together with *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Latin American Spanish both have the semantic value of $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ in (68) above, which is streamlined in (88).

$$(88) \quad \begin{array}{ll} \text{a.} & \llbracket \text{vosotros} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \\ \text{b.} & \llbracket \text{ustedes} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \quad (\text{Latin American Spanish only}) \end{array}$$

These partial identity functions trigger the presupposition that the addressee of the discourse context (u_c) is a part of individual x , or the referent of the embedded DP. Consequently, the difference between the denotation of *los lingüistas* in (87) and that of *vosotros los lingüistas* and *ustedes los lingüistas* in (89) is that the pronoun-noun constructions presuppose that one of their referents is the addressee.

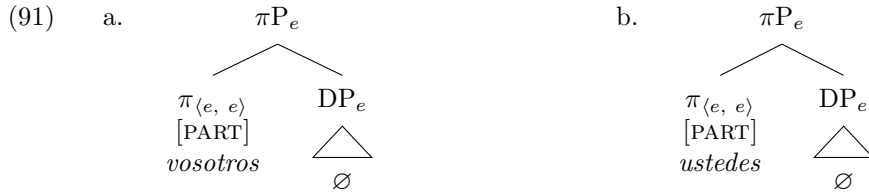
$$(89) \quad \begin{array}{ll} \text{a.} & \llbracket \text{vosotros los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ & \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x) \\ \text{b.} & \llbracket \text{ustedes los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ & \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x) \\ & \quad (\text{Latin American Spanish only}) \end{array}$$

Similarly, *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’ in (90) presupposes that one of its referents is the author of the discourse context (i_c), another unique role.

$$(90) \quad \llbracket \text{nosotros los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } i_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x)$$

I conclude that the heterogeneous plurality that certain pronouns exhibit is ultimately a person-based phenomenon, one that stems from the presuppositions that are introduced by [PART] and [AUTH].

When *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ or *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Latin American Spanish have an elided DP complement, as in (91), I consider their nominal core to lack a root and have an interpretation akin to Kayne’s (2004, 2008) light noun PERSON.



(92) a. $\llbracket \text{vosotros } \emptyset \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x)$,
defined only if $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$
and $u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x)$

b. $\llbracket \text{ustedes } \emptyset \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x)$,
defined only if $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$
and $u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x)$
(Latin American Spanish only)

According to Ackema and Neeleman (2013a, 2018), the referents of a plural second-person pronoun in Dutch can be of different social status, and the selection of an informal versus formal pronoun depends on whom the speaker takes to be the addressee. This observation strengthens the claim that addressee is a unique discourse role and can be replicated in Peninsular Spanish through a situation like the following: a surgeon has invited her adolescent daughter to have lunch with her and her colleagues at the hospital where they work. If the daughter would like to ask whether the surgeons ever collaborate on procedures, as in (93), she would likely use *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ if directing the question to her mother but *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ if directing the question to any of the other surgeons.²¹

- It would therefore be more accurate to translate *vosotros* as ‘you (informal) and others’ and *ustedes* as ‘you (formal) and others’ since these pronouns do not transmit information about perceived social status beyond that of the addressee. In other words, the extensions of *vosotros* and *ustedes* in Peninsular Spanish differ from those of *tú* ‘you (informal)’ and *usted* ‘you (formal)’ only in the addition of at least one nonparticipant, as modeled in (94).

- ²¹The choice of profession is inspired by Morgan and Schwenter's (2016) finding that speakers of Peninsular Spanish tend to use *ustedes* with medical doctors even if they use *vosotros* in other scenarios where a formal pronoun might be expected, such as with elderly family members.

- b. Extension of *vosotros*:
informal addressee + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)
- c. Extension of *usted*:
formal addressee
- d. Extension of *ustedes*:
formal addressee + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)

If, as I contend, formality is syntactically encoded by [HON], it is evident from (94) that the semantic contribution of this feature must be constrained such that it only attributes elevated social status to the addressee.

As formalized in (95), [HON] presupposes that the addressee of the discourse context (u_c) is honorable, a property that is deliberately and necessarily vague.

$$(95) \quad \llbracket [\text{HON}] \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : \text{Honorable}(u_c) . x$$

After all, speakers may not personally consider the addressee to be honorable but may still use a formal pronoun if the individual in question is substantially older than them or holds a position in society that is associated with a high level of prestige. There are, furthermore, varieties of Latin American Spanish where speakers use *usted* ‘you (formal)’ with close friends and even family members, so the denotation of [HON] must be relatively underspecified. As for second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{HON}]}$, the presuppositions that are triggered by the features on this head can be conjoined and simplified as in (96).

$$(96) \quad \begin{aligned} \llbracket \pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{HON}]} \rrbracket^c &= \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x \wedge \text{Honorable}(u_c) . x \\ &= \lambda x_e : \text{Honorable}(u_c) \leq x . x \end{aligned}$$

The semantic value of *usted* in all varieties of Spanish and of *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ in Peninsular Spanish follow in (97).

$$(97) \quad \begin{aligned} \text{a. } \llbracket \text{usted } \emptyset \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(\text{Person})(x), \\ &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and} \\ &\text{Honorable}(u_c) \leq \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(\text{Person})(x) \\ \text{b. } \llbracket \text{ustedes } \emptyset \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x), \\ &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and} \\ &\text{Honorable}(u_c) \leq \iota x_e \text{ MAX}(*\text{Person})(x) \\ &\text{(Peninsular Spanish only)} \end{aligned}$$

That is, *usted* denotes a unique maximal individual x , and this expression is defined only if such a unique maximal individual exists and the addressee is honorable and a part of this individual.²² Analogously, *ustedes* in Peninsular Spanish denotes a unique maximal sum of individuals x , defined only if such a unique maximal sum of individuals exists and the addressee is honorable and a part of this sum. The fundamental point is that [HON] has the same interpretation in both pronouns, an outcome that is not only theoretically desirable but also empirically justified.

²²In this case, the addressee and the referent of the DP are the same individual, which is possible because the relation between u_c and $\iota x_e \text{ MAX}(\text{Person})(x)$ in (97a) is one of parthood ($\leq$), not of proper parthood ($<$).

8 Conclusion

On the basis of two syntactic phenomena, I have determined that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are bona fide second-person pronouns in Spanish and not third-person nominal imposters, as Collins and Ordóñez (2021) posit. First, *usted* and *ustedes* are sensitive to the Person-Case Constraint, like second-person pronouns and unlike third-person pronouns. Second, these forms can appear in pronoun-noun constructions, such as *usted el experto/usted la experta* ‘you (formal) the expert’ and *ustedes los expertos/ustedes las expertas* ‘you the experts’, whereas third-person pronouns and imposters cannot. I then used an [HON] feature to differentiate *usted* and *ustedes* as vocabulary items from the other second-person pronouns of Spanish and argued that this feature participates in up to two postsyntactic impoverishment operations. In all varieties of Spanish, [HON] causes [PART] to be eliminated in the morphological component of the grammar, the consequence of which is that *usted* and *ustedes* cannot trigger second-person agreement. In Latin American Spanish, [HON] itself is deleted in the environment of [PL] at logical form and, as a result, does not factor into the denotation of *ustedes*, the sole plural form of address. By maintaining [HON] in the vocabulary items that correspond to *usted* and *ustedes* in all varieties of Spanish, this proposal accounts for the morphological connection between these pronouns even when they differ in expressing formality.

The Catalan data in (98) and the Portuguese data in (99) illustrate that Spanish is not the only Western Romance language to have grammaticalized the equivalent of *vuestra merced* ‘your mercy’ and *vuestras mercedes* ‘your mercies’ into members of their pronominal inventories.

- (98) Catalan
- a. *vostra mercè* ‘your mercy’ → *vostè* ‘you (formal)’
 - b. *vostres mercès* ‘your mercies’ → *vostès* ‘you all (formal)’
- (99) Portuguese
- a. *vossa mercê* ‘your mercy’ → *você* ‘you, you (formal)’
 - b. *vossas mercês* ‘your mercies’ → *vocês* ‘you all’

Like *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish, these forms all have second-person interpretations but occur with default agreement morphology, so an impoverishment-based account is viable across the board. The first two pronouns, *vostè* ‘you (formal)’ and *vostès* ‘you all (formal)’ in Catalan, both express politeness, so they can be analyzed like *usted* and *ustedes* in Peninsular Spanish. The last pronoun, *vocês* ‘you all’ in Portuguese, only expresses politeness in certain parts of northern Portugal, so it can be analyzed like *ustedes* in Peninsular Spanish in these regions and like *ustedes* in Latin American Spanish elsewhere. The third pronoun, *você* ‘you, you (formal)’ in Portuguese, has a more nuanced empirical landscape, especially in Brazil. In varieties where *você* expresses politeness, it can be analyzed like *usted* in Spanish, and in varieties where it does not, [HON] is uniformly subject to impoverishment at logical form such that this feature is not interpreted in either *você* or *vocês*.

As for languages that have recruited one or more of their existing pronouns for formal address, one issue that has not been discussed in the literature is whether

these derived honorifics have the same syntactic representations as the original forms. Pronoun-noun constructions suggest that there are at least some cases where they do not. In section 6, I mentioned that the source of *Sie* ‘you (formal), you all (formal)’ in German is *sie* ‘they’, and as shown in (100), the two guises of this pronoun behave differently in terms of their ability to be immediately followed by a noun.

- (100) a. Haben Sie Linguisten eine Lösung gefunden?
 have you linguists a solution found
 ‘Have you (formal) linguists found a solution?’
 b. *Haben sie Linguisten eine Lösung gefunden?
 have they linguists a solution found
 Intended: ‘Have they linguists found a solution?’

This contrast raises the possibility that *Sie* is syntactically second person, in which case it would have acquired a [PART] feature in the course of its evolution into a formal pronoun, just like *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish. The comparison goes even further in that *Sie* would have likewise needed to develop an [HON] feature to distinguish it from second-person plural *ihr* ‘you all (informal)’, which could in turn be responsible for the deletion of [PART] during morphological operations and the use of default plural *haben* ‘(they) have’ rather than second-person plural *habt* ‘(you all) have’ in (100a). More research into *Sie* is warranted, especially from a diachronic perspective, but this initial foray into its featural composition demonstrates how the analysis that I have proposed for formal pronouns that have nominal origins could be extended to those that have pronominal origins as well.

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